

only to those people who want nothing but Linux on that particular hard drive.

In RedHat, the various modes of installation aren't too well categorised. It allows you to install a workstation style, server style or development style, which leaves no space for any normal or home user distribution. However, you may have to do a custom install and choose the packages you need most. Like SuSE, RedHat also allows you to choose to boot into X when you boot up into Linux.

Mandrake is another distribution like RedHat. As in RedHat, the partition had to be created manually. Mandrake has two main modes of installation: Recommended and Expert.

We also came across some really bad installation interfaces and styles, which we would not recommend for home users. Storm Linux has a custom-based installation mode in which categories and packages have to be chosen manually. This is good for the advanced Linux user.

Turbo Linux had a completely ncurses-based installation style with no X running during the installation. ncurses is a text-mode colour display system like DOS's Ansi colour graphics. This allows you to install the distribution using only the keyboard.

The boot manager is one of the main features of a Linux distribution as this is the tool that allows you to switch or dual-boot between Linux and other operating systems. We therefore checked for a boot manager and the various options offered. All of the distributions installed their boot managers well. SuSE, RedHat and Mandrake have good colourful interfaces for the boot loaders. Corel Linux Second Edition is also very user friendly when it comes to installation, but we had some trouble installing the boot loader. Turbo Linux has a completely plain text-based LILO prompt. Overall, installation ease hasn't changed much from earlier versions though the interface has

changed in most of the top distributions. SuSE and Mandrake are currently distributions that can be installed easily or without much trouble.



Mandrake:
Trying to forge an
identity of its own

Hardware troubleshooting

Detection of hardware has been an issue with Linux in the past, and is another factor that has hampered its wider adoption.

After doing all the tests in hardware detection, we found that all the distributions with the latest kernels and applications were able to detect all the hardware.

All the distributions tested, except for one or two, could not detect one component here and there. All distributions except Storm Linux could auto detect the hardware. The S3 Trio would run perfectly at 1024x768 along with the monitor. The D-Link 100 MBps network card also worked perfectly on the network. Majority of the distributions could detect the network card and the other components during the installation procedure itself.

Usually the card and monitor can run perfectly at 1024x768 on any operating system, but in Linux Mandrake we had a bit of trouble running our graphics card at 1024x768 at 32-bit colour. At this resolution, we witnessed a bit of distortion on the desktop while running X and we had to reduce the resolution to 800x600 to make the display run perfectly. The trouble was not just with Mandrake. We found that Storm Linux was worse than Mandrake because it failed to detect any of our hardware, including the monitor and the network card. We tried the different variants

of the S3 Trio card with various monitors, but in vain. We finally had to settle for a virtual desktop running at 16 colours and continued with the remaining tests with these settings for Storm Linux.

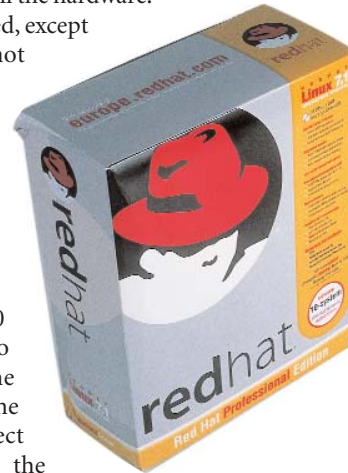
All those apps

Shortage of applications is one problem that most people expect with Linux. The truth is that Linux has a wide range of open source applications available over the Internet and there are sites such as www.freshmeat.net that regularly give you a preview of what's in store.

GIMP, Electric Eye and KDE Media Player are common applications installed by default with most of the distributions that have KDE or Gnome installed on them (all the

distributions we tested had either KDE or Gnome installed). A simple set of card games is also installed by default. Netscape Navigator and Konquer are the browsers that you will usually find. However, there are other manuals and support, which may be included with the whole package.

The distributions that we tested came with a big collection of CDs. RedHat and SuSE provided us with the maximum number of CDs. SuSE comes parcelled with seven CDs, which includes the installation CDs and extra packages. RedHat gives you 11 CDs with a huge variety of applications.



RedHat: good hardware
detection capabilities

Types of Linux Distributions

Linux is not just a desktop-based operating system. In fact, Unix and its variants have been better known as servers. The same is the case with Linux. Today, there are Linux distributions that can fit into a single floppy, and yet include various services such as a Web server, a firewall, a software router, etc. All it takes is downloading an image from the Internet and writing it on a floppy. After that you can simply run a whole server off that floppy.

Linux currently supports various systems ranging from PPC (PowerPC), Intel to SPARC and even mobile processors or embedded chipsets. You even have Linux distributions that can be installed just like

another Windows application, such as WinLinux and Linux for Windows 9x, which will run off a FAT partition that stores another virtual UMSDOS file system, thus eliminating the need to create a separate Linux partition or a boot loader.

E-smith server and gateway is a distribution that is meant for servers and it runs mail servers, POP3 and telnet on it. Calcaria Linux is a small distribution that allows you to run Linux on Psion-based Palmtops. There are even distributions that act as firewalls. Language-specific distributions aren't rare anymore and you do have distributions for foreign languages.